

Village Council Minutes — Forestry & Reforestation Findings

What the village's own council record already says about the forest problem, before this project existed

1. Why this document exists

`research/council_minutes/` is a locally-built archive of 100 Mitsue village council-meeting transcripts (H29/2017–R8/2026), extracted and searched for budget/contract keywords. That original scan wasn't built to surface forestry policy discussion — it was built for capital-project tracking. This document is a targeted follow-up pass, reading the actual passages where councilors and the Mayor discuss forest management, to find anything that supports, contradicts, or sharpens this project's forest workforce and reforestation thesis.

None of the findings below appear in `research/council_minutes/projects.csv` (that file only tracks single contracts over ¥10M) — they're policy answers and budget-line context buried in longer transcript passages.

2. Findings

2.1 御杖村森林環境整備基金 (Village Forest Environment Improvement Fund)

Established by ordinance 議案第1号, passed at the **same March 2019 (Heisei 31) council session** as the ECC/グローバル人材育成塾 ordinance (議案第2号) — both created back-to-back at that meeting. The fund banks unused 森林環境譲与税 (national Forest Environment Transfer Tax, a per-year transfer to the village running roughly ¥26M–38M depending on year) for future forest projects, rather than letting unspent allocation lapse.

Source: `research/council_minutes/text/H3103teireikaikaigiroku.txt`, lines 44, 159, 759–868.

2.2 森林経営管理制度 (Forest Management Stewardship System) — the real bottleneck, stated by the Mayor

National law (森林経営管理法, effective April 2019) lets the village act as intermediary between forest owners who can't/won't manage their land and capable forestry operators — or manage it directly itself, financed by the transfer tax.

Councilor 木村 asked in December 2020 what Mitsue was doing with this. **Mayor Ito's answer is the single most useful passage found:** he expects that if the village runs the owner-intent survey this law calls for, *many* owners will hand management over to the village — but the village doesn't have enough forestry operators or workers to absorb that demand:

「本村においてはその受皿となる林業経営体が少なく、また携わる林業従事者も不足しており、森林所有者の意向に対して受皿が追い付いていないのが現状です」 ("In our village, there are few forestry operators to serve as the receiving body, and forestry workers are also in short supply — the receiving capacity is not keeping up with what forest owners want.")

His stated response: build up the 森林組合 (forestry cooperative) and workforce first, including using the 地域おこし協力隊 (Regional Revitalization Corps) program to train 自伐型林業 (owner-operator-style forestry) workers, **before** running the full owner-intent survey — because surveying demand they can't yet fill would be counterproductive.

Why this matters for this project: this is the village's own stated diagnosis, from 2020, of exactly the constraint the [Forest Workforce Energy Plan](#) is built around — the bottleneck is crew and equipment capacity, not tree availability or owner willingness. This is citable, dated, on-the-record confirmation from the Mayor, independent of this project.

Source: [research/council_minutes/text/R2-12kaigiroku.txt](#), lines 503-545.

2.3 施業放置林整備（マネージャー）事業 (Neglected-Forest Management Project) — the village's current mechanism, and its scale

The village's actual current tool for the above: the **same** 村森林組合 (Mitsue Kanko, already treated in this project as the sole forestry operator — see [[project_reforestation_principle]]) is contracted to survey long-neglected, un-thinned forest, confirm the owner's intent, and — where the owner can't manage it — the village pays for thinning itself, financed entirely by the 森林環境譲与税. This thinning runs at an unusually high **40% rate** (vs. normal thinning), specifically so the forest needs no further attention for some years afterward.

As of the January 2024 session: **approximately 2,600 ha of neglected forest (放置林) still exists village-wide.**

Why this matters: 2,600 ha is a hard, sourced figure worth checking against this project's own forest-area assumptions (the workforce plan currently cites ~7,051 ha total village forest area from the co-op's own report — 2,600 ha of that being officially classified as neglected is a striking fraction, and a concrete answer to "how much forest actually needs intervention now" from the village's own survey work, not this project's estimate).

Source: [research/council_minutes/text/R6-1kaigiroku.txt](#), lines 793-805.

2.4 地域おこし協力隊 + 自伐型林業, and thinned-wood use at tourism facilities — a 2021 policy statement that anticipates this project

In the Mayor's 2021 policy address: 4 地域おこし協力隊 (Regional Revitalization Corps) members were already training in 自伐型林業 (small-scale owner-operator forestry) at the 森林組合, with plans to recruit more as a succession/workforce strategy. The same passage states an intention to **promote local circular use of thinned wood at tourism facilities** (間伐材等の地域内循環利用促進のため、観光施設等での利用施策を進めます).

Why this matters: "use thinned wood at tourism facilities" is, in substance, the heat-cascade idea already developed independently in [[project_onsen_resilience_node]] (biomass CHP heat feeding the onsen and other village facilities) — except this is village policy language from 2021, years before this project existed. Worth citing directly when pitching the onsen/CHP concept, since it shows the village had already articulated the goal, just not the mechanism.

Source: [research/council_minutes/text/R3-3kaigiroku.txt](#), lines 1093-1102.

2.5 Recent clear-cut / replanting oversight gap (Dec 2024)

Councilors raised two cases of private clear-cutting (皆伐) in the same session: 0.51 ha at 神末敷津 (the operator voluntarily planted 510 cherry trees afterward) and a larger concern at 土屋原畑井 about erosion risk with no confirmed replanting plan. The village's own admission: once a 伐採届 (logging notification) is filed, all it can do is

encourage (促してまいりたい) appropriate replanting — there is **no binding requirement** that clear-cut land be replanted, or replanted with any particular species mix.

Why this matters: this is a live, current (Dec 2024) governance gap, on the record, that this project's [[project_reforestation_principle]] — native broadleaf replanting for ecosystem value, not just re-planting sugi for future harvest — is positioned to fill. It also means "who replants and with what" is presently unregulated, which cuts both ways: an opportunity to lead by example, but also no legal lever forcing other operators to follow suit.

Source: `research/council_minutes/text/kaigirokuR6-12.txt`, lines 279–337.

2.6 Smaller named programs (surfaced but not detailed further)

- **美しい森林基盤整備事業** (Beautiful Forest Infrastructure Development Project) — a prefecture-subsidized line item, ¥4.436M in the FY2025 budget (`kaigirokuR7.txt`, line 1618). No further detail found in the transcripts; would need the source budget document.
- **水源林造林事業** (Water-Source Forest Afforestation Project) — appears as an inter-municipal advocacy/lobbying item ("関係団体と要望活動を実施") rather than a direct village project — the village and partner bodies pushing for budget at a higher level of government (`kaigiroku.txt` line 250, `r7dai2kaiteireikaikaigiroku.txt` line 201). Worth checking who the "関係団体" (partner organizations) are if this becomes relevant to funding outreach.

2.7 Reforestation funding vs. thinning funding — an important distinction

Everything in §2.1–2.3 that involves **actual village-spent money** (森林環境整備基金, 施業放置林整備事業) pays for **thinning** (間伐) of existing sugi/hinoki plantations — none of it funds **new planting/reforestation** (造林・植林).

The only 造林-related funding references found are a different kind of activity: the 全国/近畿北陸 水源林造林協議会 (National / Kinki-Hokuriku Water-Source Forest Afforestation Council). Mayor Ito attends this **as Nara Prefecture's chairman representative**, roughly annually (`kaigiroku.txt` line 250, `r7dai2kaiteireikaikaigiroku.txt` line 201, `3009ka.txt` line 442 — spanning at least 2018–2025). Each time, the report is the same pattern: the assembly reaffirms the importance of afforestation and **resolves to lobby national government for budget** (国へ要望、陳情を強力に行うことを確認) — this is an **inter-municipal advocacy body**, not a funding source, and it does not put money into Mitsue's own budget.

Why this matters: there is no village-budget line currently funding new tree-planting anywhere in this archive — only thinning of what's already there. That makes this project's reforestation principle (native broadleaf replanting, not just re-planting sugi) a genuine funding and mechanism gap, not something that risks duplicating an existing village program. It also means the Mayor is *already* personally positioned as a national afforestation-funding advocate — a natural point of alignment if this project seeks national-level afforestation subsidies, since he's already lobbying that exact system for other reasons.

Source: `research/council_minutes/text/kaigiroku.txt` line 250; `r7dai2kaiteireikaikaigiroku.txt` line 201; `3009ka.txt` line 442.

3. Suggested next steps

- **Cite §2.2 (Mayor's 2020 workforce-bottleneck statement) directly** in funding pitches and the workforce plan — it's independent, dated, on-the-record village confirmation of this project's core thesis, which is more persuasive than the project's own framing.

- **Cross-check the 2,600 ha neglected-forest figure (§2.3)** against the workforce plan's area assumptions — worth a footnote or a revision if it changes the addressable-area math.
- **Use §2.4's "thinned wood at tourism facilities" language** when pitching the onsen/CHP heat-cascade concept to village officials — reframes it as "delivering on a goal you already stated" rather than a new idea.
- If pursuing the reforestation/replanting-oversight angle (§2.5) as a policy argument, confirm whether 2,600 ha (放置林) and clear-cut sites are the same category of land or distinct — they weren't described as connected in the transcripts.
- **Use §2.7 in the Mayor meeting** — see the question below.

4. Question for the Mayor meeting

Building on §2.2 (workforce bottleneck), §2.3 (village currently funds thinning only), and §2.7 (no village or advocacy-body funding currently reaches new planting):

Would the Mayor be interested in the NGO taking the lead — in coordination with the village hall — on **reforestation** specifically (new native-broadleaf planting), as distinct from the thinning work the village already funds through 施業放置林整備事業? Concretely: would he support the village setting up **additional funding for 御杖村森林組合 (Mitsue Kanko)** — new machinery and an expanded workforce — so the co-op can carry out this reforestation work, with the NGO directing species selection and site priority per [[project_reforestation_principle]]?

Why frame it this way: it doesn't ask the village to replace or compete with 施業放置林整備事業 — it proposes a second, distinct funding stream for a gap the village currently has no mechanism for (§2.7), operated by the same co-op the village already trusts and contracts (§2.3), with the NGO providing direction rather than asking the village to fund the NGO directly. That mirrors the ordinance-based, co-op-delivered structure the village already uses, rather than proposing something organizationally new.

All findings sourced directly from `research/council_minutes/text/` transcripts (see per-section citations above), not from `projects.csv` or `keyword_hits.csv`, which were built for a different (capital-contract) purpose and did not surface this material.